

# **Color Term Variation in Japanese Sign Language: Diversity, Change, and Dialectal Variation**

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20 minutes to present + 10 minutes for Q&A.

# **Introduction**

- **Japanese Sign Language (JSL) shows rich dialectal variation across regions and generations.**

# Introduction

- Like spoken language, dialects and variations in Sign Languages emerge through linguistic change shaped by geographic separation, community norms, and cultural influences.

| English                                                           | ASL<br>【PINEAPPLE】                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>THAT REMINDS<br/>ME WHERE<br/>I'M FROM IS...</b>               |   |
| <b>pop</b> <i>(Midwest)</i> carbonated beverage                   | <b>【S-L version】</b>                                                                 |
| <b>bubbler</b> <i>(Midwest and New England)</i> drinking fountain |  |
| <b>jawn</b> <i>(Philadelphia)</i> thing, a catch-all term         | <b>【Initialized version】</b>                                                         |
| <b>lagniappe</b> <i>(Louisiana)</i> a little something extra      |                                                                                      |
| <b>hella</b> <i>(California)</i> very                             |                                                                                      |
| <b>sourdough</b> <i>(Alaska)</i> native, longtime resident        |                                                                                      |
| <b>hotdish</b> <i>(Upper Midwest)</i> casserole                   |                                                                                      |
| <b>moe</b> <i>(Washington, D.C.)</i> friend, associate, homie     |                                                                                      |

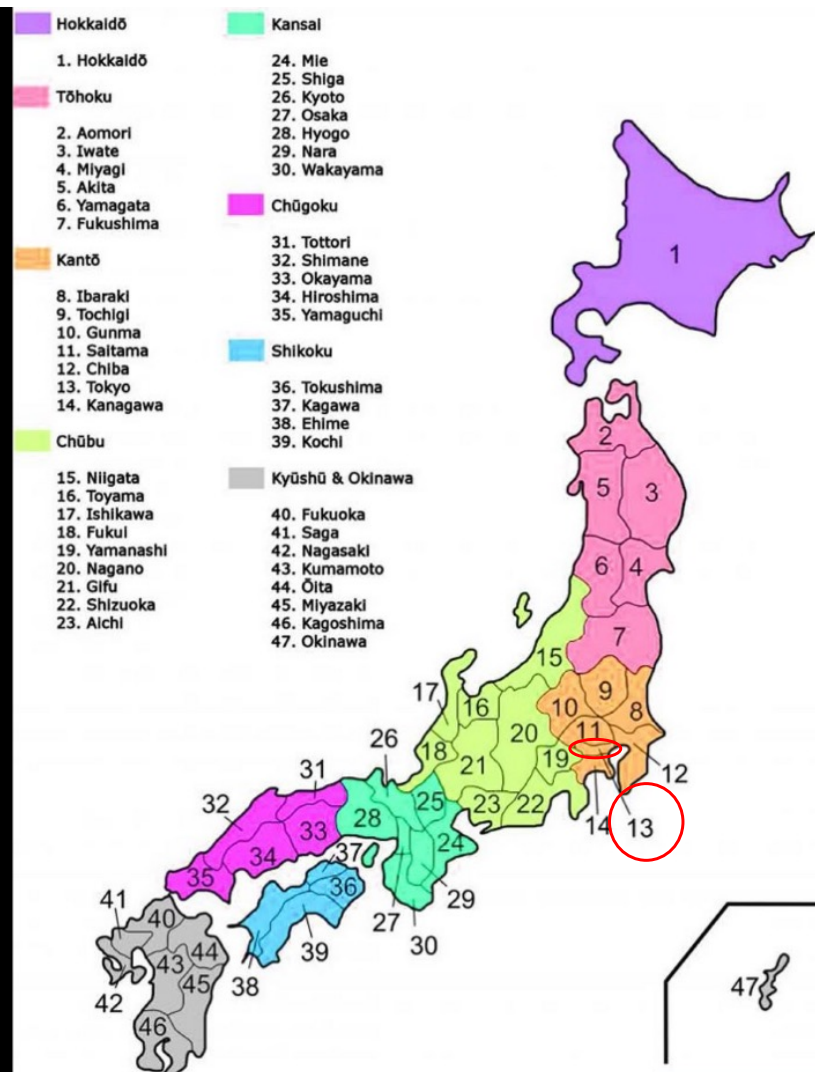
## Background

- **Dialect...Reflect the identity of a region or social group.**



# Background

- **Dialect...Reflect the identity of a region or social group.**
- **A unique variation of a language spoken by specific regions or social groups. (Chambers & Trudgill, 1998).**
- **Japan**  
**[8 regions and 47 prefectures]**



## Background

- **Dialect...Reflect the identity of a region or social group.**
- **Social factors such as economic disparity, education, and interpersonal relationships promote linguistic diversity(Wardhaugh & Fuller, 2015).**



# Background

| Year | Events                                                                                          |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1878 | Japan's first Deaf School was established in Kyoto.                                             |
| 1878 | The Milan Congress promoted oralism.<br>Ban on JSL in education and public spaces (Sasaki 2018) |
| 1965 | Kyoto deaf students protested against the sign language ban.                                    |
| 1966 | Reintroduction of JSL into education in every deaf schools.                                     |



# Previous Research

- Studies confirm that even within the same region, JSL signs differ lexically across prefectures (Yonaiyama, 2003).

<https://youtu.be/BhvNx1rLtA8?si=ifbk99DN4iFs7Ho>

- Research on Deaf vocabulary in Japan (Osugi, 2012)



SUNDAY 1

SUNDAY 2

- Non-manual markers of manner adverbs—such as those in Ehime (Uchibori & Ueda, 2023)
- Regional lexical differences— (Kishimoto, 2024) in Hokkaido.



# Research Question 1

Previous studies show JSL differences (e.g., Ehime, Hokkaido), influenced by local culture and identity.

**However...Untouched  
Regional JSL color variation.**

**Are there lexical  
differences in Color  
Term signs between  
prefectures within the  
same region?**



# Data

- **Used JSL video corpus data.**  
[Corpus Project in Colloquial Japanese Sign Language (Bono et al., 2014)].

- **140 Deaf from 7 regions**

- **Each region × age group:  
4 participants (2 males, 2 females)**

**[Gunma, Ishikawa, Nara,  
Toyama, Nagasaki, Ibaraki,  
Fukuoka]**

- **Adding to interviews with  
Kyoto signers.**



# Methods

|        | 30's | 40's | 50's | 60's | 70's |
|--------|------|------|------|------|------|
| Red    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| White  | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Black  | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Yellow | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Green  | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Blue   | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Brown  | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Purple | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Pink   | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Gold   | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |
| Silver | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |

|     | 30's | 40's | 50's | 60's | 70's |
|-----|------|------|------|------|------|
| Red | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    | ▶    |

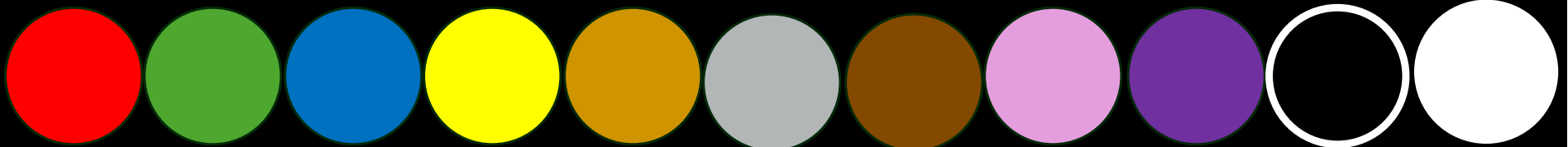


Male 30's



Male 70's

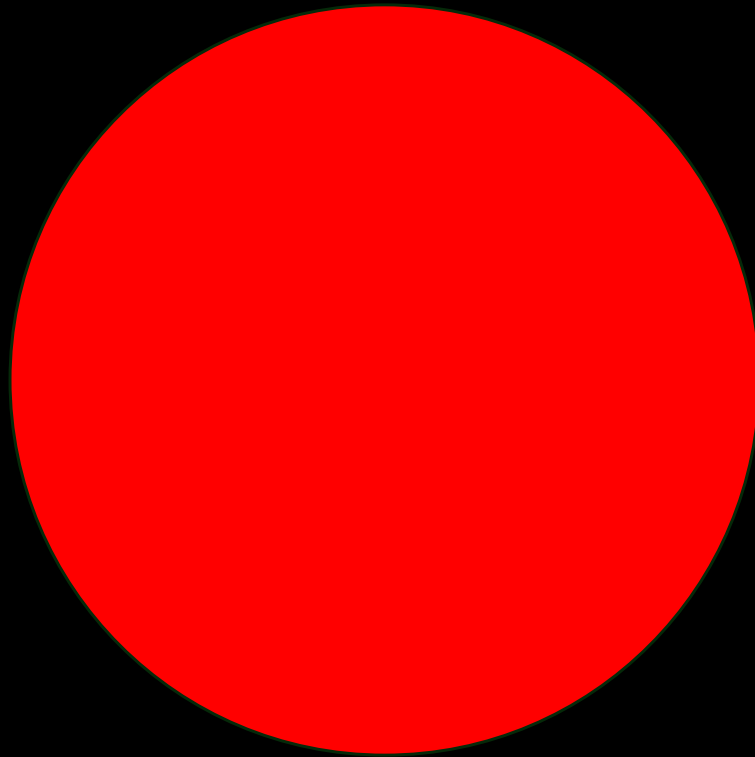
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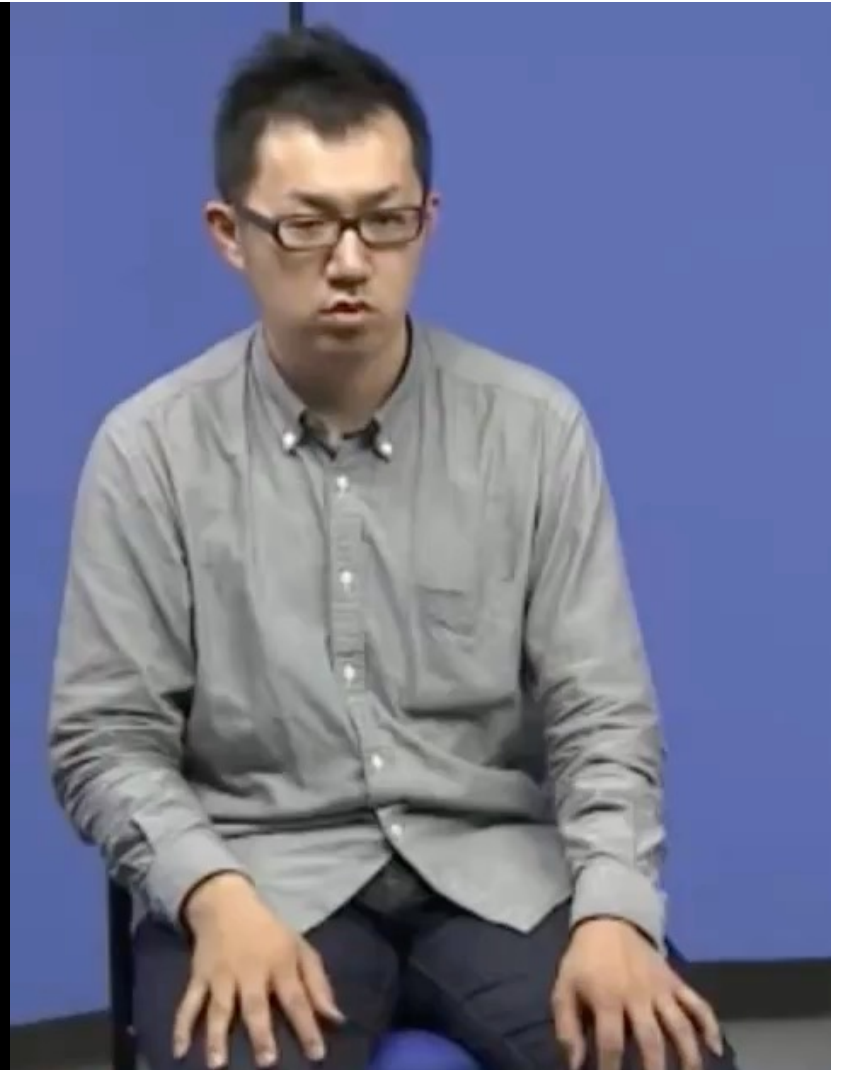
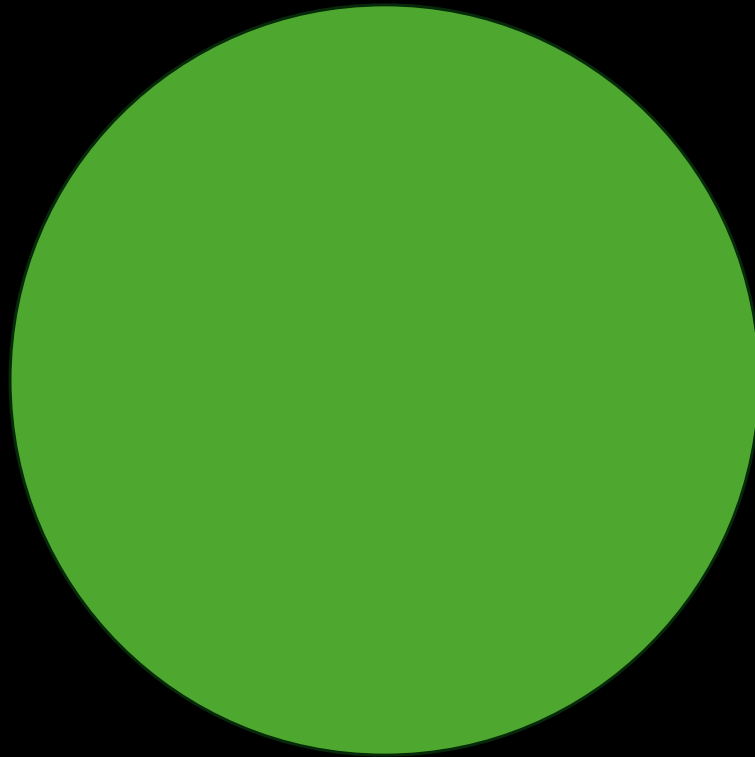
Using variationist sociolinguistic methods (Labov, 1966, 1972; Eckert, 2012; Hill, 2017).

Analyze the distribution and progression of color term variation over time

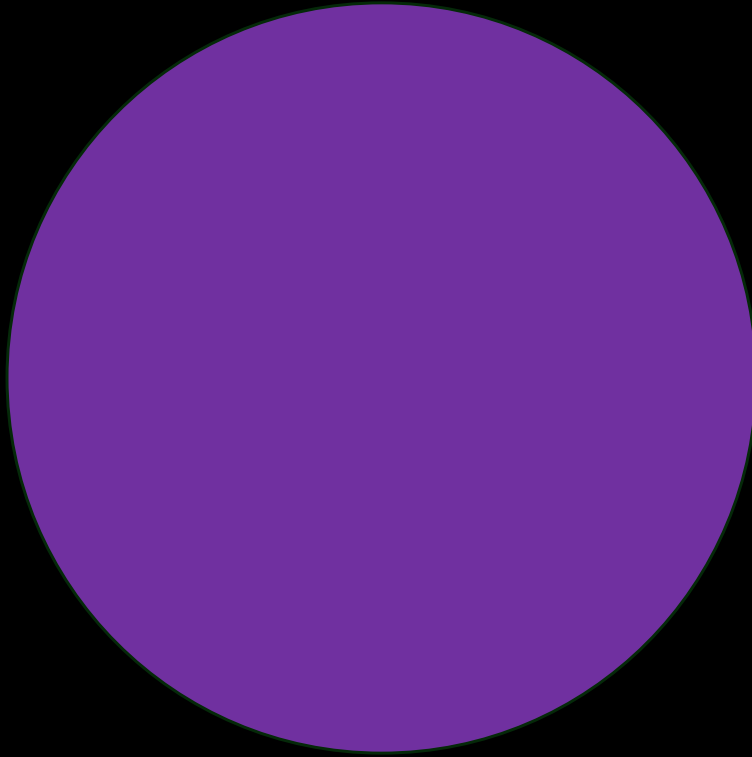
# Results



# Results

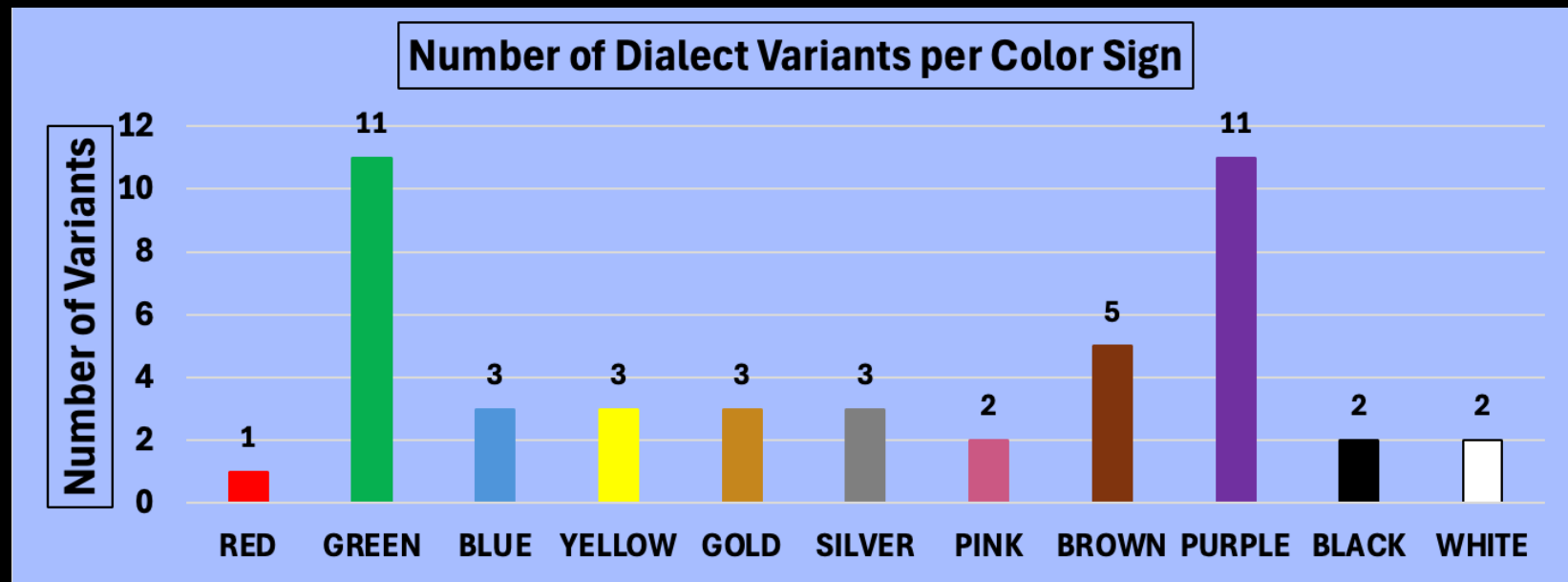


# Results



## Results

- Are there lexical differences? **YES**

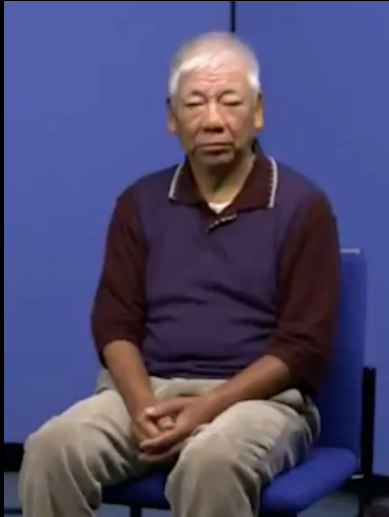
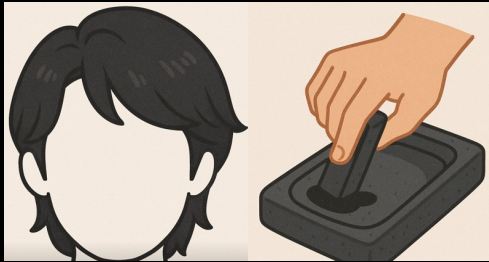


**GREEN and PURPLE show high variation,  
while RED and BLACK have fewer variants.  
But each reflects traditional or cultural reasons.**



## Discussion

**Findings: Reflects traditional or cultural reasons.**



**BLACK**



**BROWN**



**WHITE**

# Research Question 2

Do phonological changes explain lexical differences in color signs across JSL dialects?



**RED**



**BLACK**

# Research Question 2

Do phonological changes explain lexical differences in color signs across JSL dialects?

**YES**



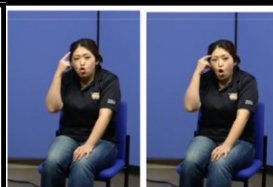
|     |                      |
|-----|----------------------|
| HS1 | I                    |
| MO  | Opposite to Dominant |
| LO  | N/A                  |



|     |     |
|-----|-----|
| HS1 | 1   |
| MO  | tap |
| LO  | N/A |



|     |                      |
|-----|----------------------|
| HS1 | 1+flat               |
| MO  | Opposite to Dominant |
| LO  | N/A                  |



|     |                              |
|-----|------------------------------|
| HS1 | 1                            |
| MO  | DOWN                         |
| LO  | Top to bottom of the temple. |



|     |                                   |
|-----|-----------------------------------|
| HS1 | 5                                 |
| MO  | DOWN                              |
| LO  | Top of the temple to the shoulder |



|     |                        |
|-----|------------------------|
| HS1 | 5                      |
| MO  | UPDOWN                 |
| LO  | Temple top to forehead |

**RED: 20s, 40s, 70s**

**BLACK: 30s, 40s, 70s**

## **Handshape Changes**

- *RED*: Pinky (younger) vs. Index/knuckle (older)
- *BLACK*: Varies by hair length, style

## **Movement & Orientation**

- Generational shifts in motion and direction
- Older forms are more complex

## **Social Factors**

- Practicality & cultural embodiment shape forms
- Standard signs spread via social media etc, reducing regional use

## **Future Directions**

- **Explore how different Deaf communities (e.g., Deaf communities across the eight regions and 47 prefectures of Japan) conceptualize and sign color.**
- **Develop culturally informed teaching materials that reflect lexical variation in JSL.**
- **Promote educational outreach to bridge generational and regional gaps.**

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**Thank you for watching**